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Democracies and newsrooms get strengthened when they challenge, not silence, controversial figures

Theocracies and monarchies were always shrouded in a veil of absolute power. What's under siege now is this century's most revered political system, DEMOCRACY itself. Its institutions unable to contain the big personalities of their leaders. The checks and balances within which democratic leadership operated have been breached. We have now what I am calling PERSONACRACIES. Democracies that revolve around a personality. It seems democracies can also legitimise absolute power. Some may even say that's the need of the hour.

On the eve of this war, Saturday, February 28, we had just returned from Tehran. We had gone to do an exclusive interview of Iran's foreign minister, Abbas Araghchi, who is today a household name. After his interview with us in a mesmerising hall of mirrors, he left for the peace talks in Geneva. Our flight was a day later, so we wandered the streets of Tehran. A window into Iran has been restricted and we were curious.

A dusty city moving to the holy rhythm of Ramzan, unaware of the epic fury that was about to be unleashed. Tehran is not pretty or historic like a postcard demands. Its people are the real attraction. Warm and poetic, answering our questions in verse and anecdotes.

Maybe you think I am taking sides. Yes, I am. The side of all of us. The side of humanity, of all people. The side of our brilliance. The side of little laughter that lights up a room. The side of clear blue skies. The side of houses that become homes. The side of love that binds family. The side of flowers that bloom. The side of prayers that are answered. The side of those who hoped when all else failed. The side of invisible strings that bind us together. Or SHOULD bind us together.

There are so many truths and sides to this war, and we try to bring you multiple perspectives. We have assembled 10 foreign envoys, so that you can have an informed point of view. In fact, that is always our effort with the conclave and the newsroom. Everyone doesn't always agree with our guest list. We invited Yasin Malik, and an ideological section had an issue; we invited Salman Rushdie and Congress had an issue; we invited Dalai Lama and the Chinese had an issue. This year, too, some sections have questioned our speaker choices. We believe that democracies and newsrooms are strengthened not by silencing, but by challenging, controversial figures and putting their views up for scrutiny. We don't shy away from difficult conversations. We believe engagement, not exclusion, is the way to resolution. And maybe if more of us thought so, we could have avoided this war. So many countries are now scarred by this war thrust upon them and just see the death toll. Everyone counting their own.

Yet this war doesn't care for nationalities, it reduces all, yours and theirs, to rubble. Prime Minister Narendra Modi has often spoken of one earth, one family, one future. Others need to pay heed.

Over the past few weeks, our fragile planet has been pounded with three times the explosive yield of the atomic bombs of World War II. Yuval Noah Harari, the modern-day historian, has warned "could it even be that we are already in the midst of the third world war, and we just haven't realised it yet? If you ask people, let's say, in May 1941, they would not have told you that they are living in the midst of the second world war. Only with hindsight, we understand it." In hindsight, this war against Iran will be seen either as one that protected all humanity from bad actors, oppression and nuclear Armageddon. Or it could just be World War III.

So many countries are now scarred by this war thrust upon them, counting their dead. Yet this war doesn't care for nationalities, it reduces all to rubble

I want to end with the words of celebrated poet Mahmoud Darwish. "*The wars will end and the leaders will shake hands, and that old woman will remain waiting for her martyred son, and that girl will wait for her beloved husband, and the children will wait for their heroic father, I do not know who sold the homeland, but I know who paid the price.*"

It's a reflective note with which to wrap Conclave 2026. But in the end, we celebrate what we have. This moment. And this moment is alive because of US, and we must honour it by living it in FULL. ■